F/A - 18A-D HORNET & F/A - 18E/F SUPER HORNET

OVERVIEW

The F/A-18E/F Super Hornet is a highly capable aircraft operated by the United States Navy across the full mission spectrum, including air superiority, fighter escort, reconnaissance, aerial refueling, close air support, suppression of enemy air defenses, and day/night precision strike missions. It is the second major evolution of the F/A-18 platform, succeeding the legacy F/A-18A-D Hornet, which remains in service with the United States Marine Corps until its planned transition to the F-35 Lightning II is completed around 2030.

MISSION

The F/A-18E and F/A-18F were designed to meet the U.S. Navy's fighter escort and interdiction mission requirements while maintaining the F/A-18's fleet air defense and close air support capabilities. They also support an expanding range of missions, including Forward Air Controller (Airborne) and aerial refueling, having successfully replaced the S-3 Viking in the aerial tanker role.

HORNET/SUPER HORNET VARIANTS

The F/A-18 Hornet and F/A-18 Super Hornet are available in both single-seat (A, C, E) and dual-seat (B, D, F) variants. The dual-seat variants support pilot training and expand mission capabilities by accommodating a Weapons Systems Officer (WSO) in the rear cockpit during operational missions.

CAPABILITIES

The F/A-18 Hornet and Super Hornet are all-weather, twin-engine, mid-wing, carrier-capable, multirole tactical aircraft. In the fighter role, they are primarily used for fighter escort and fleet air defense. In the attack role, they conduct force projection, interdiction, and both close and deep air support missions.

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General Characteristics, F/A-18 Hornet, A-D models
Primary Function: Multi-role attack and fighter aircraft.
Contractor: Prime: McDonnell Douglas; Major Subcontractor: Northrop.
Date Deployed: November 1978. Operational - October 1983 (A/B models); September 1987 (C/D models).
Unit Cost: $29 million
Propulsion: Two F404-GE-402 enhanced performance turbofan engines. 17,700 pounds static thrust per engine.
Length: 56 feet (16.8 meters)
Height: 15 feet 4 inches (4.6 meters)
Wingspan: 40 feet 5 inches (13.5 meters)
Weight: Maximum Take Off Gross Weight is 51,900 pounds (23,537 kg).
Airspeed: Mach 1.7+
Ceiling: 50,000+ feet
Range: Combat: 1,089 nautical miles (1252.4 miles/2,003 km), clean plus two AIM-9s Ferry: 1,546 nautical miles (1777.9 miles/2,844 km), two AIM-9s plus three 330 gallon tanks.
Crew: A, C and E models: One B, D and F models: Two

General Characteristics, F/A-18 Hornet, E/F models
Primary Function: Multi-role attack and fighter aircraft.
Contractor: McDonnell Douglas (now The Boeing Company)
Date Deployed: First flight in November 1995. Initial Operational Capability (IOC) in September 2001 with VFA-115, NAS Lemoore, California. First cruise for VFA-115 is onboard the USS Abraham Lincoln.
Unit Cost: $67.4 million (FY21)
Propulsion: Two F414-GE-400 turbofan engines. 22,000 pounds (9,977 kg) static thrust per engine
Length: 60.3 feet (18.5 meters)
Height: 16 feet (4.87 meters)
Wingspan: 44.9 feet (13.68 meters)
Weight: Maximum Take Off Gross Weight is 66,000 pounds (29,932 kg)
Airspeed: Mach 1.8+
Ceiling: 50,000+ feet
Range: Combat: 1,275 nautical miles (2,346 kilometers), clean plus two AIM-9s
Crew: A, C and E models: One B, D and F models: Two